

By Mihir Srivastava

Every day the headlines unleash a new horror. On June 12, three boys take turns at raping a Class XII girl in the backseat of a moving car in Surat and record the act for perversity on their phones. Two days later, India wakes up to the news that actor Shiney Ahuja has been accused of raping his 18-year-old domestic help, who's half his age and body weight. On June 19, a 19-year-old college girl is gangraped after her boyfriend and his friends circulate an SMS clip they shot of their first assault. The same day, a 19-year-old English NGO volunteer is brutalised by two taxi drivers in Palampur, Himachal Pradesh. And on June 22, a woman from Inderpuri in India's rape capital, Delhi, alleges that six policemen ganged up on her inside a police station in the afternoon. The datelines differ, the crime remains the same.

What drives a man, whether it is a seemingly successful actor or a group of testosterone-loaded young men, into such sexual violence? Are they motivated by lust? Or are they powered by their innate rage against women? Who are these devils in disguise? An in-depth study by a Delhi-based NGO, Swanchetan, of 242 inmates of Delhi's Tihar Jail over five years unravels the mind of a rapist and shows that it could be anyone. More worryingly, as the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) data shows in 92 per cent of all rape cases, it could be someone you know. And trust.

Most of the rapists studied by Swanchetan had committed multiple rapes—on an average at least four—before they were caught. They harboured an intrinsic hatred of women, habitually referred to them abusively, almost dehumanising them as objects of desire. They had an insatiable desire to enact their sexual fantasies on the victims they targeted and would operate in different geographical locations, with a change of place adding a new thrill. No surprise then that over 70 per cent of them showed psychopathic traits, belying the belief that rape is a sick crime committed by sane people. As many as 68 per cent of the rapists in the Swanchetan study had difficult childhoods, what Delhi-based psychiatrist Jitendra Nagpal calls "extended paedophilia".

Photograph by HEMANT CHAWLA
Model RAVI SAHANI

Soft Targets

- 9.5% of those raped were under 15
- 15.2% were girls between 15 to 18
- 57.7% were women in the age group of 18 and 30
- 17% women were between 30 and 50
- Worse, 0.6% were over 50

In 92.5% cases, the offender was known to the victim

- 2.1% cases of rape involved a parent or a close family member
- Neighbours were responsible for 36% of the cases
- In 7.5% of the cases, relatives of the victim were involved

The Rape Sheet

Number of rape cases reported in a year

Delhi	Indore	Jaipur
530	74	62
Mumbai	Pune	Bangalore
177	67	62

The Crime Capital

- 68% of Delhi's rapists were illiterates or school drop-outs
- 24% studied up to Class X
- 21.9% were graduates
- 80% of the accused were poor

Source: National Crime Records Bureau.
All figures belong to the year 2007.